

IF YOU DIDN'T TASTE IT, IT ISN'T YOURS

There's a particular kind of shame that only happens in a kitchen.

Not the "oops, I messed up" kind.

The kind where you feel your insides fold in on themselves while you still have to keep moving because service doesn't give a shit about your spiritual crisis.

Mine arrived the first time I sent a sauce I hadn't tasted.

It was a midweek dinner service, one of those nights that pretends to be gentle at the start. A couple of early tables, a quiet rail, the illusion that maybe we'd get out before midnight and remember what outside air feels like.

By seven-thirty, the printer was having a breakdown.

Tickets spitting out in clumps. Starters, mains, modifiers, allergies, someone wanting a "chef's choice vegetarian" even though there was already a vegetarian main on the menu—but apparently this one needed a custom identity arc.

I'd been bumped up to work a little corner of the hot line. For an apprentice, that's not a promotion—it's a test. "You can either swim or we'll let you sink in front of everyone and see if you crawl out on your own."

My list was simple on paper: warm the garnish, bring the jus back to life, keep plates looking like they came from the same kitchen and not a community fundraiser.

We had a red wine jus on that week—veal stock base, reduced down, glossy, expensive, the sort of thing that makes people think the dish is "worth it" when they see the price. The base lived in a deep pan on the back, ticking over gently, and for service we'd pull off what we needed into smaller pans, reduce, mount with butter, adjust, send.

Tonight, one of those little pans was mine.

I took a ladle of base, dropped it into a sauté pan, set it over the flame. Let it reduce while I threw a garnish into another pan, listened to the pass

call tickets, tried to see ten minutes into the future like everyone else on the line.

It looked right.

Thickening, darkening, catching the light.

I tossed a knob of butter in, did the swirl I'd seen everyone do since day one, and for half a second, I let myself think, *Yeah, I've got this.*

Then the dockets hit:

"Three sirloin, one lamb, all with jus, two medium rare, one blue, one well done because of course."

I fired the pans, seared the meat, dragged my garnish together. The grill was barking times, the pass was counting down, everyone was running that edge between control and collapse.

I reduced the sauce a touch more. Lifted the pan. Looked at it.

Convinced myself I didn't have time to taste it.

The base was good yesterday. It would be fine.

I told myself that and believed it because believing it was faster.

I plated.

Napkin under the plate, protein down, garnish neat, jus over the top. I sent four plates to the pass in one go and felt that tiny flicker of pride you should never, ever entertain in the middle of service.

Two minutes later, one came back.

"Table ten says the sauce is too bitter," the waiter said, doing that apologetic half-grin that means they agree but don't want to get stabbed with a fish slice.

Chef didn't look at the waiter. He looked straight at my station.

"You seasoned it?"

"Yes, Chef."

"You tasted it?"

There's no way to bluff that one.

My throat tried to form a lie and my tongue just... didn't cooperate.

"No, Chef."

He walked over, grabbed a clean spoon from the pot, dipped it into my pan and tasted. No theatrics. No commentary. Just one slow nod, like a doctor confirming what you already know.

Then he turned to the rest of the section.

"Taste this," he said.

Not the whole brigade—just the people around me. Grill, garnish, the guy on fish. Quick, efficient, one spoon each, tap-tap into the pan, taste, move on. No speeches.

Every single one of them pulled the same face.

That microscopic wince you try to hide but can't.

The jus was bitter.

Too far reduced. The wine pushed past balanced into that dry, clinging, tannic place you can't fix with a bit of sugar and charm.

Chef didn't drag it out. He tipped the contents of my pan into the bin, gave the base on the back stove a quick taste, and ladled fresh into a clean pan himself.

"You're back on garnish. I'll finish the jus," he said.

No screaming, no big scene—which somehow felt worse. It meant I wasn't important enough to yell at, just wrong enough to be removed.

Service rolled on. Plates went up. The line stayed intact.

The only thing that really took damage was my ego and a four-plate run on table ten's first impression.

It wasn't until after service—when the grills were off and the dining room had finally spat everyone back out into the night—that he circled back.

He pulled a small pot, ladled some of the same base in, set it over a low flame, and nodded at me.

"Bring this down," he said. "Slowly. Then mount it. We're not going home until it tastes right."

No big lecture. No "let me show off my wisdom" monologue.

Just work.

We stood there in the half-quiet kitchen: dishwasher still going, someone scraping the flat-top, the last of the night's adrenaline wearing off like a fading buzz. I reduced. He watched. Occasionally he'd tell me to lower the heat, or skim, or leave it alone.

When it looked right, he shoved the spoon pot towards me.

"You first," he said.

This time I tasted it before he asked.

And I actually thought about it—the texture, the balance, the way it sat. Not just "is it salty enough," but *does this say what it's supposed to say?*

It was good.

Not life-changing. Not something to write poetry about. But correct. Clean. Balanced.

He tasted it after me, gave the smallest nod, and that was it. No praise. Just acceptance.

And weirdly, that was enough.

Because the real difference wasn't the sauce.

It was the part of my brain that quietly rewired itself to never let anything leave my station untasted again.

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ChefTip #7

"If you didn't taste it, it isn't yours."

If your hands have touched it, your name is on it. Full stop.

Sauces, purées, dressings, oils, marinades, the last second of seasoning on a steak—if you haven't tasted it in the state it's going out, you don't know what you're serving.

Not what it was. What it is now—after reduction, after being held on the corner of the stove, after the fifteenth "just one more minute" while you juggle three other tickets.

Flavours move. Salt creeps up. Acidity dulls. Heat digs out bitterness you didn't know was hiding.

Tasting isn't insecurity.

It's responsibility.

Every spoon is you saying: *If this comes back, it comes back with my fingerprints on it—and I'm not finding out what's wrong from a waiter.*

And yeah, when you get it wrong, it stings.

Having your mistake lined up for others to taste is brutal.

But that's the part that etches itself into you so it doesn't happen again.

You taste. You adjust. You stand by it.